Teaching the Next Web

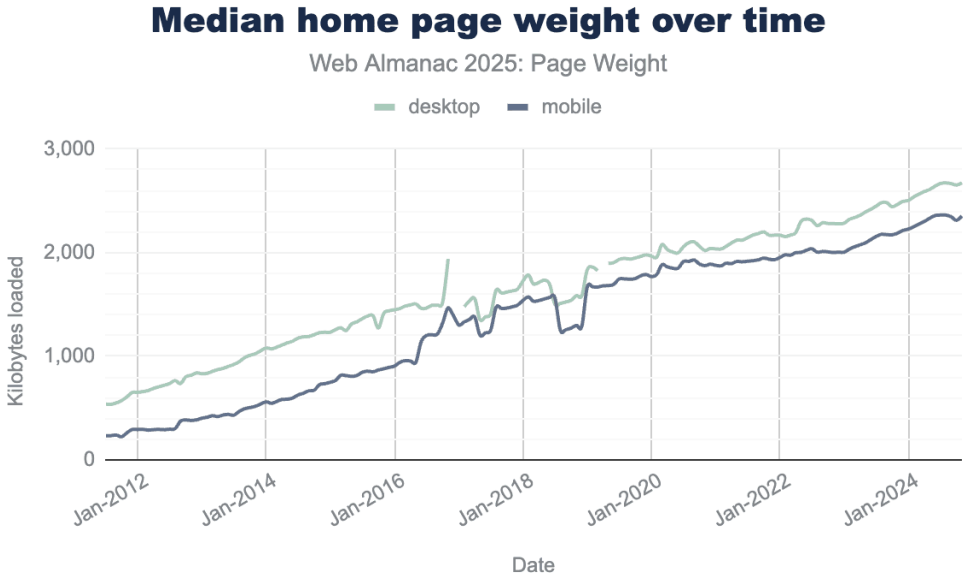
From hybrid rendering to agentic hypermedia

Juho Vepsäläinen

6.5.2026

Why this matters now

We often have the practices to reduce complexity, but too little incentive to adopt them.



Reference: HTTP Archive Web Almanac 2025, Page Weight, Fig. 14.1

Why this matters now

Agents now shape the web in two ways: they help build websites and increasingly consume them.

Agentic development

Agents increasingly help code, modify, and maintain web applications.

Agentic search

Systems now browse and compare sources on the user's behalf. [7], [8]

Browser use

Agents increasingly operate websites directly, not only retrieve information. [9], [10]

Outline

Part 1	Research highlights
Part 2	From research to teaching
Part 3	Future vision and goals
Part 4	Conclusion

Part 1

Research highlights

Hybrid rendering models

Dissertation: Vepsäläinen, J. (2025). Emergence of hybrid rendering models in web application development.

Dissertation background

From static content to web applications.

The platform was designed for static content, then evolved into an application platform.

Choose rendering strategies case by case.

Application size tripled in a decade while mobile constraints remained.

Main claims

Rendering should follow use cases.

The mainstream SPA model should be used more sparingly.

Hybrid rendering narrows dynamic behavior to where it is needed.

Islands constrain dynamic scope. Resumability avoids hydration and enables code-splitting.

Simplification agenda

How do we reduce unnecessary complexity without giving up capability?

Revisiting Hypermedia, The Forgotten Web Application Development Paradigm

Vepsäläinen • TechRxiv • 2026

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The Case for HTML First Web Development

Vepsäläinen • JWE (accepted) • 2026

Part 2

From research to teaching

AI and computing education

Educational implications

- **Curriculum and pedagogy need rethinking.**

What changes in practice

Assessment and classroom design

Flipped learning, oral exams, dialogical assessment.

[1] Vepsäläinen, J., & Juntunen, P. (2026). Artificial intelligence for computer science education - hype or help?

AI and computing education

Educational implications

- **Curriculum and pedagogy need rethinking.**
- **Integrity is not the only issue.**

What changes in practice

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Flipped learning, oral exams, dialogical assessment.

Beyond integrity

Also trust, over-reliance, bias, and unequal access.

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AI and computing education

Educational implications

- **Curriculum and pedagogy need rethinking.**
- **Integrity is not the only issue.**
- **The goal is responsible technical judgment.**

What changes in practice

Assessment and classroom design

Flipped learning, oral exams, dialogical assessment.

Beyond integrity

Also trust, over-reliance, bias, and unequal access.

Durable skills

Critical reading, writing, debugging, reflection.

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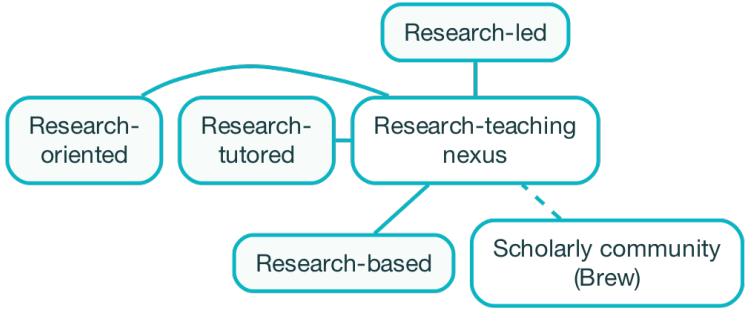
How research informs my teaching

- **Build working models students can adapt.**
  Research helps me teach principles, not only tools.

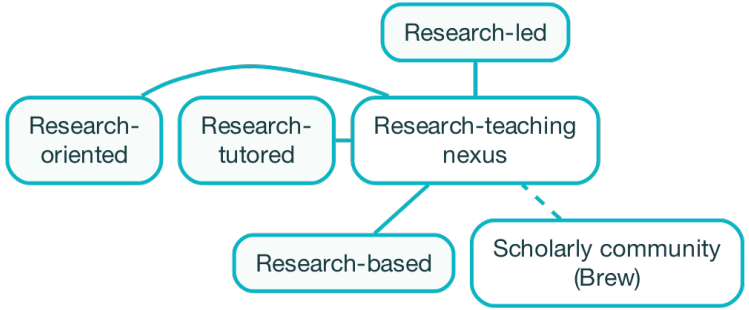


Research-teaching nexus [3,4]

How research informs my teaching

- **Build working models students can adapt.**
  Research helps me teach principles, not only tools.

- **Teaching and supervision shape my questions.**
  Student work reveals topics that deserve more attention.



Research-teaching nexus [3,4]

Research with students

20+
BSc theses since 2022

6
MSc theses advised

Current advising work covers agents and MCP, hypermedia, microfrontends, cloud migration, and WebAssembly.

- **Pyry Pohjalainen (2025): AI for web development; AAAI Magazine.**
- **Anoop Bidikar (2024): Stateful serverless architectures at the edge.**
- **Antti Nousiainen (2024): WebAssembly in edge computing.**

Writing support

A writing process students can use

- **Shared writing process improves supervision.**
  "The Process of Scientific Writing" makes publishing expectations concrete.

- **Students can use it on their own.**
  It supports supervision through a shared writing process.

Public learning communities

Teaching also happens outside courses

- **I organize Future Frontend.**

  Meetups and the conference keep me grounded in current practice.

- **My developer background supports my teaching.**

  webpack-merge is one example; earlier work includes webpack and Blender.

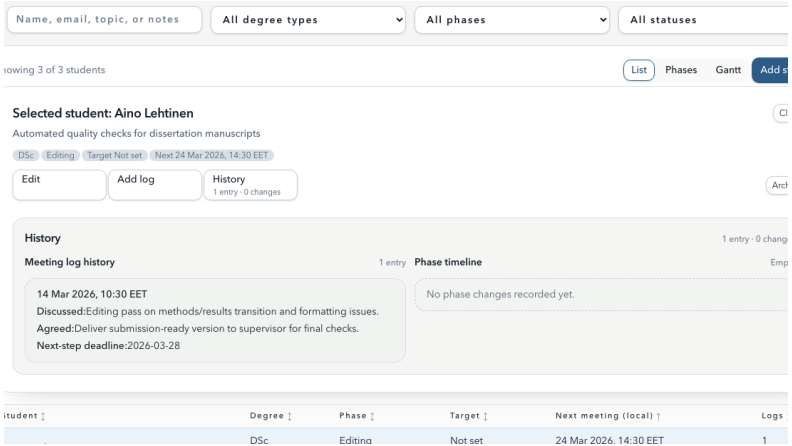
Teaching outside the classroom

Future Frontend is one way I do it.

Tools that support my work with students

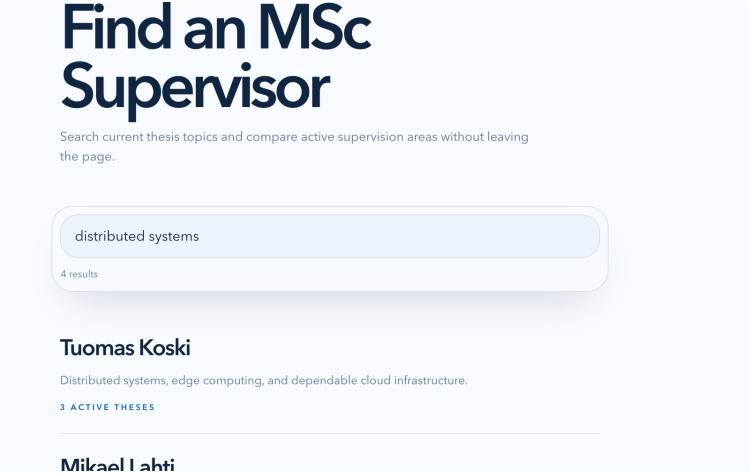
Thesis Journey Tracker

Phases, meetings, and notes in one place.



Supervisor Search

Find suitable MSc supervisors without leaving the page.



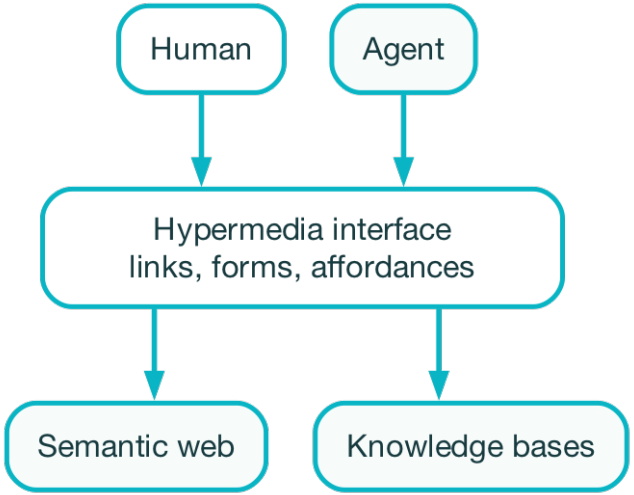
Part 3

Future vision and goals

Future vision: agentic hypermedia

Research questions

- How do we keep the web usable by agents?
- How do semantic web ideas and knowledge bases support agent-facing systems?
- What should remain stable in web architecture as agents become users?



[2], [5] Fielding; Berners-Lee et al.

Future teaching at Aalto

- Starting in January 2027, I will teach Designing and Building Scalable Web Applications (CS-E4770) and use it to teach web architecture as a core computer science topic, not only as framework practice.

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- On 13th of October 2026, I will organize AI meets SDLC at Marsio to connect teaching, research, and industry.

Part 4

Conclusion

Conclusion

I strengthen Aalto's web architecture teaching with research on agent-facing systems.

Q&A

References

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